

NERAI INTELLIGENCE
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Russia-Ukraine War Trajectory: Major Offensive & Tactical Nuclear Risk Assessment

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY - BOTTOM LINE UP FRONT

Russian tactical nuclear use within the next 12 months remains unlikely in the base case - our structured estimate is 3-6% (central value near 3.5-4%), LOW CONFIDENCE, derivation shown in the Annex - but it is materially higher than before 2022, and it rises sharply where two conditions compound: a major battlefield reversal AND a genuine regime-survival shock. We frame internal regime stress as a CONDITIONAL RISK MULTIPLIER, not as an independent pathway: fuel-supply strain, economic discontent and eroding public patience are strain indicators worth weekly monitoring, but none of them is yet evidence of elite fracture, command-and-control change, or a leadership that perceives existential threat. The estimate for the compound branch - reversal plus shock - is 15-30%, a structured analyst judgment consistent with the only public quantified precedent (reported U.S. internal estimates during the autumn-2022 Kherson crisis [28]) and with the 2025 DIA judgment that use becomes plausible only when leadership perceives a regime-existential threat [15].

On use-preparation indicators, the picture is mixed and honestly stated: open sources show NO evidence of a large-scale increase in warheads assigned to non-strategic roles - though the production rate itself is unknown, and with roughly 1,800 such warheads already in inventory, stockpile stasis says little about limited-use intent [12][13]. Against that quiet: exercise and integration indicators have moved distinctly. The 19-21 May 2026 unannounced exercise combined strategic and non-strategic forces across some 65,000 troops and, for the first time on film, rehearsed physical transfer of (likely dummy) warheads to a Belarusian Iskander unit in the field [8][9][10][11]. Custody of real warheads shows no observed movement.

On the conventional question: a qualitatively larger Russian offensive within 6-12 months is possible but not the base case - we hold 15-25%, analyst judgment at MODERATE-TO-LOW confidence, and we engage the counter-evidence squarely: the 2026 U.S. Annual Threat Assessment records that Russia's ground forces have GROWN during the war and its air and naval forces remain largely intact [14]. The constraint case rests on flow, not stock: contract recruitment is tracking roughly 5% behind its proportional target with the daily intake falling year-on-year, standards are being relaxed, and advances cost over 400 casualties per square kilometre in Donetsk [17][18]. North Korean augmentation - per Ukrainian intelligence claims relayed by Reuters, not independently verified [4] - extends the grind rather than creating breakout capability.

KEY FINDINGS

[HIGH CONFIDENCE - narrow claim] Open sources show no evidence of large-scale increase in warheads assigned to non-strategic roles: the 2026 FAS estimate holds ~1,794 such warheads within ~4,400 total, and the U.S. State Department's 2026 report finds no indications of large-scale increase [12][13]. Two limits stated plainly: the production rate is unknown (production, retirement and refurbishment are separate variables the public record does not resolve), and an inventory of ~1,800 already suffices for any limited-use scenario - so this indicator is quiet, but it is weak evidence about intent.

[HIGH CONFIDENCE] Exercise and integration indicators moved in May 2026: the unannounced combined exercise (strategic launches plus non-strategic play, Belarusian launch sites, ~65,000 troops) included a filmed field transfer of warhead mock-ups to a Belarusian Iskander unit [8][9][10]. The FPRI and OSW analyses describe this same May activity [8][11]; no separate July exercise occurred - v2's contrary claim was a misreading of a July-dated analysis and is withdrawn. Joint TNW drills with Belarus have nonetheless moved from novelty (2024 series) to practiced routine.

[HIGH CONFIDENCE] The doctrinal floor was lowered on 19 November 2024 - not 2025 - and release authority remains with the President alone; no delegation exists in the published text [1][2].

[MODERATE-TO-LOW CONFIDENCE] A qualitatively larger offensive is not the base case (15-25%, analyst judgment). The honest ledger: AGAINST - daily recruitment intake falling year-on-year (~1,200 in 2024 to

~1,090 mid-2026), medical standards relaxed, 400+ casualties per km² seized, armour regeneration drawing on finite storage [17][18][19]; FOR - ATA 2026: ground forces grew during the war, air and naval forces largely intact, and Russia 'sees little reason to stop fighting' [14]. The 195,000-by-July figure against a 409,000 annual goal is roughly on proportional pace and is NOT itself evidence of failure; the trend variables are.

[UKRAINIAN INTELLIGENCE CLAIMS - RELAYED BY REUTERS, NOT INDEPENDENTLY VERIFIED]
North Korean augmentation: ~9,500 troops in Kursk currently outside direct operations; ~150 KN-23/24 missiles delivered since late 2023 plus a new 40-missile batch; a ~90-person missile unit deploying within Russia's 112th Missile Brigade (Voronezh) with up to six launchers and 120 missiles; a possible further tranche of up to 30,000 personnel [4][5][6][7]. Downstream outlets largely relay the same Kyiv/Reuters chain - they are one source, not several. Higher circulating figures (50,000) are unverified.

[MODERATE CONFIDENCE] Internal strain is real and worsening, and it is a multiplier, not a pathway. June-2026 Levada readings: 64% support negotiations, 29% support continuing the war, 67% still profess support for the armed forces; war attention at record lows; financial-deterioration reports doubled since early 2024 [24][25][26]. The fuel crisis persists into August 2026 [23]; at its 2025 peak, Ukrainian strikes idled a record ~17% of refining capacity (August 2025 comparison point [21]). None of this evidences elite fracture or regime-security alarm - the watchlist exists precisely to catch the onset.

[LOW CONFIDENCE] External dissuasion is real but conditional, and no specific, verifiable Chinese conditionality statement is in evidence. The DIA's conditional - use unlikely UNLESS leadership perceives regime-existential threat [15] - remains the controlling public anchor, and it is the reason the compound branch, not any single axis, carries the concentrated risk.

BACKGROUND & CONTEXT

The war is in its fifth year. Russia holds the initiative along most of the front and converts it at extraordinary cost; the UK Defence Intelligence cumulative casualty estimate passed one million in 2025 [20]. Ukraine's deep-strike campaign against Russian fuel infrastructure operates at two levels - refining capacity and distribution - and produced an acute, persisting fuel crisis: the record ~17% of capacity idled dates to August 2025 [21], detailed strike analysis in [22], and the Soufan Center's August 2026 assessment finds the crisis ongoing though absorbable so far [23]. Russia's answering pattern has been massed drone and missile waves against Ukraine (the 537-drone strike of 30 August 2025 remains the scale reference [21]) and deepening reliance on North Korea, formalized in the June 2024 treaty [3].

The nuclear background: the November 2024 doctrine revision [1][2]; the 2023 agreement to store non-strategic munitions in Belarus [8]; the 2024 non-strategic exercise series that first brought Belarus into TNW play; and the May 2026 escalation of that line into unannounced, combined, transfer-rehearsing form [8][9][10][11]. Against this: no observed movement of actual warheads, no confirmed warhead presence in Belarus, no evidence of large-scale non-strategic stockpile growth [12][13], and four years of unexecuted red lines. Yet the 2026 U.S. Annual Threat Assessment sharpened its own language: the escalation spiral in Ukraine, including nuclear exchange, is named the most dangerous threat Russia poses, with deliberate as well as inadvertent pathways [14][16].

ANALYSIS - Interpretive Framework: Two Axes, One Multiplier

v2 of this report argued the main nuclear pathway now runs through slow battlefield failure compounding with internal stress. External review correctly flagged that as ahead of its evidence, and v3 adopts the defensible form: the battlefield axis remains primary; the internal-regime axis is a **CONDITIONAL MULTIPLIER** whose current readings are strain, not fracture. What the strain data - approval erosion, record-low continuation support, fuel

and fiscal stress [21][23][24][25] - actually establishes is that IF a major reversal arrives, it lands on a regime with less domestic slack than at any point in the war, which is why our conditional shock probability WITHIN Scenario C (30-40%) is roughly double the baseline (15-20%). Both numbers are structured judgments, stated as Assumption A2 in the Annex, not measurements.

Duration enters the analysis as a variable through the flow arguments: recruitment intake declining year-on-year, armour regeneration drawing down finite storage, casualty-per-gain ratios worsening [17][18][19]. Sunk cost (a million-casualty-scale war [20]) raises the price of termination short of claimable victory; in a personalist system that is the mechanism by which gambling-for-resurrection behaviour enters the tail of the distribution. We claim the mechanism's relevance, not its activation: nothing in the current record shows leadership perceiving existential threat, and the DIA conditional [15] therefore currently binds DOWNWARD.

ANALYSIS - Task 1: The Larger Offensive Question

The stock-versus-flow ledger decides this question, and the two sides point differently. STOCK (argues capability): ATA 2026 - ground forces larger than at the war's start, air force and navy largely intact, initiative held [14]. FLOW (argues constraint): contract recruitment ~195,000 by early July against a 409,000 annual goal - approximately on proportional pace but ~5% behind target with the daily rate down year-on-year and standards relaxing [17][18]; 400+ casualties per square kilometre seized in Donetsk [17]; 2024 tank losses replenished largely from finite storage [19]. A force with growing stock but deteriorating flow can sustain and even intensify grinding pressure; assembling the concentrated, trained, equipped mass for a qualitatively larger offensive is a different matter. Judgment: 15-25% within 12 months, MODERATE-TO-LOW confidence - presented as judgment, not demonstration.

North Korean augmentation modifies the ledger's flow side - an attrition subsidy (rotational manpower) and standoff augmentation (the Voronezh missile unit, if activated) - but the entire DPRK picture rests on a single sourcing chain (Ukrainian intelligence via Reuters [4]) and is treated accordingly. Indicator 3 of the watchlist carries the follow-on tranche question.

ANALYSIS - Task 2: The Tactical Nuclear Threshold, Indicator by Indicator

1. PRODUCTION - no evidence of large-scale increase in warheads assigned to non-strategic roles; production rate unknown [12][13]. Stated at that width and no wider. Given ~1,800 existing warheads, this indicator's quiet is weak evidence about limited-use intent; its diagnostic value would be in a REVERSAL of the flat trend, which is why it stays on the watchlist despite low current information content.
2. CUSTODY & MOVEMENT - no verified movement of actual warheads from 12th GUMO storage to delivery units; no visually confirmed warhead presence in Belarus. What changed in May 2026: the transfer PROCEDURE was rehearsed on film with a Belarusian Iskander unit [8][9]. Rehearsal is not enactment; it converts paper capability into practiced capability. Status: warm infrastructure, cold movement.
3. EXERCISES - the clearest observed upward trend: occasional single-service drills before 2024; the first joint non-strategic series with Belarus in 2024; the unannounced combined May 2026 exercise with Belarusian launch sites and hypersonic delivery play [8][9][10][11]. (One exercise, multiple analyses: the July-dated FPRI piece describes the May event [11].)
4. RHETORIC - elevated plateau, not spiking. Doctrine-anchored signalling continues and Western analysis reads it primarily as coercion [27]. We track decision-maker specificity, discount commentary-class rhetoric to zero, and retain v1's well-supported insight that rhetorical volume has historically moved inversely to real readiness steps.

5. CONTEXT TRIGGERS - trending adverse but well short of doctrinal thresholds. Strikes reach deep into Russian fuel infrastructure [21][22][23]; internal strain accumulates [24][25]. Nothing in the record shows the regime treating these as existential in the doctrinal sense [1][15].

NET READING: production quiet (weakly informative); custody rehearsed, not enacted; exercises institutionalizing; rhetoric plateaued; triggers converging slowly from a distance. Supports: low base-case probability, materially above pre-war, concentrated in the compound branch.

NERAI DATA INTEGRATION

Evidence base: [NERAI] platform indices and regime states - [VERIFIED] retrieved reporting per the numbered bibliography - [INFERENCE] analyst judgment, labelled inline - [SCENARIO] conditional constructs in the forecast tree.

Platform readings as of 11 August 2026 [P]: Russia regime state CRISIS (level 2 of 3, hidden-Markov classification over NERAI's daily event-intensity indices); military-escalation topic at its 100th percentile against its own history, +42 points versus its 90-day mean; military-clash at the 100th percentile; confiscate-property at the 98th percentile, +53 - an independently derived internal-coercion reading consistent with, but not proof of, the war-economy strain visible in open reporting [21][23]. Ukraine mirrors the escalation readings. Methodology and limits in the Annex; the standing caveat applies - percentiles are pressure gauges ranking each series against its own history, never probabilities, and the regime model's escalation-probability field saturates at Crisis state and is not used.

SIGNAL INTERACTION MAP

How the axes couple - the cross-signal paths single-indicator monitoring misses. (1) Fuel-fiscal path: deep strikes on refining [21][22] feed fiscal stress, which feeds internal coercion (NERAI confiscate-property, 98th pct [P]), which raises the political price of a second mobilization - narrowing the conventional-regeneration exit and pressing the calculus toward negotiation (Scenario B) or, under compound stress, the A-plus-shock cell. (2) DPRK path: standoff augmentation [4][5] invites deeper Ukrainian counter-strikes, widening path (1); if the target set drifts toward strategic-force-adjacent assets, it opens the inadvertent-escalation channel the ATA flags [14]. (3) Dissuasion path: each increment of internal stress weakens the state-level rationality on which external restraint operates [15]. All three paths converge on the compound cell of the scenario grid - which is why that cell, not the cinematic Scenario C headline, deserves the planner's attention.

COUNTER-THESIS

The coercive-theatre school - the mainstream Western reading [27] - holds that every observed indicator is signalling infrastructure: doctrine revised for deterrent effect, exercises choreographed, Belarus basing political architecture without confirmed warheads, production flat because no use is contemplated, and four years of unexecuted red lines as the controlling base rate. On production and custody - the genuinely quiet indicators - this school is right, and our low base-case band partly reflects acceptance of its case.

Its vulnerability is the stationarity assumption: that the signaller's stability is a constant. Every dissuasion mechanism it invokes operates on a regime making state-level calculations; the DIA's own formulation carries the conditional clause [15]. Where we part from v2: we no longer claim the conditional is being approached - we claim its input variables (approval, continuation support, fiscal slack [24][25][21]) are all moving adverse, at unknown distance from any threshold. That is an argument for monitoring architecture, not for a raised headline number - and our headline band is accordingly unchanged by the internal data.

SCENARIOS & FORECAST (12-month horizon)

The tree is exhaustive; scenario probabilities sum to ~100 at midpoints; conditional TNW probabilities apply within scenarios; the overall band is the weighted sum. Everything here is structured analyst judgment at LOW CONFIDENCE - see the Annex derivation and assumptions, including A1 (the pre-war comparison prior is an informal analyst assumption, no published anchor exists) and A2 (internal-shock probabilities are judgments from strain indicators, not measurements).

Scenario A (50-60%) - grinding continuation, Russia slowly advancing at high cost. Flow constraints worsen but do not break; DPRK subsidy sustains tempo. TNW: 1-3% absent an internal shock; 4-8% with one (shock probability within A held at the 15-20% baseline). This branch carries the largest single share of total nuclear risk by weight of probability - the reason it must not be filed under reassurance.

Scenario B (15-20%) - effective freeze or negotiated pause. Levada's 64% negotiation support [25] gives domestic room to claim victory and stop. TNW: under 1%.

Scenario C (12-18%) - major Russian reversal: loss of the Crimean land corridor, front-section collapse, or strike-campaign paralysis of regime-symbolic capacity. Internal-shock probability within C: 30-40% (reversal itself feeds stress - Assumption A2). TNW: 8-15% without shock; 15-30% with - the maximum-risk cell, sized against the reported autumn-2022 internal U.S. estimates under a then-feared front collapse [28].

Scenario D (8-16%) - Russian strategic success through Ukrainian force degradation or Western support rupture. TNW: under 1%.

Weighted overall: approximately 3-6%, central value near 3.5-4% (Annex table). Calibration context: informal pre-2022 expert priors for any nuclear use in a given year sat well under 0.5% (Assumption A1); our band is roughly an order of magnitude above that. The number is low. It is not small, and it is not a model output - it is a disciplined guess with its reasoning shown.

POLICY RECOMMENDATIONS

1. Risk owners with Russia/Ukraine exposure (CROs, security directors; standing): plan against the A-plus-shock cell, not only Scenario C. The compound path gives less warning than the cinematic one. Success metric: playbooks that trigger on internal-axis indicators, not only front-line movement.
2. Monitoring teams (weekly): run the two-axis watchlist below; score all eight indicators every week; treat single-chain reporting (currently the entire DPRK picture) as one source regardless of outlet count.
3. Scenario planners (quarterly): stress-test the 15-30% cell for market, supply-chain and security posture consequences, using expected loss - not probability - as the planning variable.
4. All consumers: demand the derivation. Any nuclear-risk number presented without its assumptions table - including ours - should be treated as rhetoric.

NERAI FORECAST JUDGMENT

FORECAST: no Russian tactical nuclear use within 12 months - 94-97%; use - 3-6% (LOW CONFIDENCE, structured estimate). Qualitatively larger offensive attempt - 15-25% (MODERATE-TO-LOW CONFIDENCE). The single most consequential and least certain input is Assumption A2, the internal-shock probability.

FALSIFIERS - UPWARD (any one moves the estimate immediately): verified 12th GUMO warhead movement outside exercise context; visually confirmed warheads in Belarus; a reversal of the flat non-strategic stockpile trend [12][13]; a second mobilization decree; an elite-coercion cascade (platform confiscation and arrest indicators spiking together); presidential-level statement tying a named, imminent condition to nuclear response. DOWNWARD: durable ceasefire; refining capacity sustained above 95% for two months; approval

re-stabilization above 85%; DPRK follow-on tranche failing to materialize by year-end.

INDICATOR WATCHLIST (weekly review, ranked by diagnostic value)

- 12th GUMO warhead movements outside exercise context (HIGHEST DIAGNOSTIC VALUE - satellite, rail OSINT). The line between rehearsal and enactment.
- Belarus custody: any visual confirmation of warheads (not infrastructure); readiness state of the Belarusian Iskander units drilled in May [8][9].
- DPRK ladder: activation of the Voronezh missile unit; size and role of any follow-on tranche against the claimed 30,000 - with independent corroboration beyond the Kyiv/Reuters chain flagged explicitly [4].
- INTERNAL - mobilization signals: legislative preparation, conscription changes, call-up infrastructure. The clearest regime-stress marker.
- INTERNAL - elite coercion: NERAI confiscate-property index (98th pct, +53 [P]) plus high-profile seizures and arrests; a coercion spike is the regime pricing its own instability.
- INTERNAL - fiscal/fuel: refining capacity offline (2025 peak ~17% [21]; crisis persisting [23]), National Wealth Fund drawdown, rationing spread.
- Decision-maker rhetoric SPECIFICITY (daily Kremlin monitoring): named conditions with timelines from the President or Security Council - not volume, not surrogates.
- Deep-strike target-set drift toward strategic-force-adjacent assets (early-warning radars, triad infrastructure; the 2024 Armavir radar strikes are the precedent) - the inadvertent channel the ATA flags [14].

WHAT WE DO NOT KNOW

- Actual warhead disposition and production rate. All custody and production judgments rest on absence of public evidence - a weak instrument against a practiced concealer. Caps every related confidence at MODERATE.
- The true internal-shock probability (Assumption A2). Wartime polling measures expressed, not held, preference [24]; A2 could be materially wrong in either direction and is the tree's most consequential input.
- The content of Chinese dissuasion. Preference for non-use is clear; specific communicated conditionality is not publicly evidenced.
- The DPRK picture beyond a single sourcing chain. Every quantitative claim traces to Ukrainian intelligence via Reuters [4]; corroboration from imagery or third-party intelligence is absent from the public record.
- Whether strain converts. We do not know where the thresholds lie between public fatigue, elite anxiety, and regime-security alarm - only that the distance is currently nonzero and shrinking on every measured axis.

ANNEX - DERIVATION, ASSUMPTIONS & NERAI METHODOLOGY

Scenario (12 mo)	Prob.	TNW no shock	TNW with shock	Leading indicators
A - Grinding continuation	50-60%	1-3%	4-8%	Recruitment intake, DPRK tranche, refinery strikes
B - Freeze / negotiated pause	15-20%	<1%	<1%	Talks signals, Levada negotiation support
C - Major Russian reversal	12-18%	8-15%	15-30%	Crimea corridor, front cohesion, 12th GUMO

D - Russian strategic success	8-16%	<1%	<1%	Ukrainian force generation, Western aid
Internal-shock probability	15-20% (baseline) / 30-40% within C	-	-	Mobilization prep, elite coercion, fiscal markers
WEIGHTED OVERALL	~3-6% (central ~3.5-4%)			Structured analyst estimate, LOW CONFIDENCE

Component	Value	Basis
P(A) x P(TNW A)	0.55 x ~0.02-0.03	shock-weighted: 0.83x(1-3%) + 0.17x(4-8%)
P(B) x P(TNW B)	0.175 x <0.01	winning/pausing Russia has no use for TNW
P(C) x P(TNW C)	0.15 x ~0.12-0.17	shock-weighted: 0.65x(8-15%) + 0.35x(15-30%)
P(D) x P(TNW D)	0.125 x <0.01	as B
Sum	~0.033-0.045	reported as 3-6% with rounding humility
Assumption A1	pre-war annual prior <0.5%	informal analyst prior; NO published anchor exists
Assumption A2	P(shock) 15-20% base / 30-40% in C	structured judgment from strain indicators; not measured
Confidence	LOW	no empirical calibration is possible for this event class

NERAI data methodology, in brief: the platform maintains ~2,300 daily country-topic intensity series from global event data (60 countries, ~40 topics). A percentile ranks today's value against the series' own full history; the 90-day delta compares against the recent mean - together they distinguish 'historically elevated' from 'recently moved'. Regime states are hidden-Markov classifications over the same series. Limits: event data measures reported activity, not ground truth; percentile saturation (100th) censors further movement; the regime model's escalation-probability field is uninformative at Crisis state. Raw series and backtests are available to clients on request; they are not reproduced here.

Sourcing discipline note: downstream repetition of one origin does not create corroboration. The DPRK claims in this report count as ONE source (Ukrainian intelligence via Reuters) however many outlets relay them; findings so based are labelled accordingly.

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